

Snapping water

A camera with a shutter speed that's slower than a second or two can be used to shoot flowing water and make it look like a painting. Set your camera on a tripod. Adjust the aperture either to f-8, f-11, or f-16 for better depth of field. Now, set the shutter speed to 2 seconds, and shoot. Since you are using long exposures, make sure that the subject is positioned in the shade. Use polarising filters to enhance the effect.

Master the modes

Digital cameras have many presets, called modes or macros that let you click photos differently. Some of the common modes are Auto, Portrait, Landscape, Sports and Night. Auto mode is the general picture-taking mode. When you use this mode, the exposure, focus, and flash are set automatically. When this mode is active, there is usually a small camera icon on your LCD to indicate it. Portrait mode, usually shown on the LCD as a face, sharpens the subject and leaves the background out of focus.

Landscape mode is indicated by mountains on the LCD, and is suited for shooting subjects that are at a distance. Often, a slower shutter speed is chosen and hence, it's better to use a tripod while using this mode. The Sports or Action mode provides a faster shutter speed and is used to shoot fast moving objects. Night mode, as the name suggests, is used to shoot in poor light condi-

tions. Since this also means longer exposures, use of a tripod is recommended.

Taking silhouettes

Silhouettes make for appealing photographs. To shoot a silhouette, first position yourself with the sun somewhere in front of you. Now, set the exposure on the brighter part of the scene. Use the exposure lock button to secure the exposure. Re-compose the photo and shoot. If it doesn't have an exposure lock button, set the exposure compensation to -2 or -3.

Slideshows and screen-savers

To view your pictures as a slide show in Windows XP, open the images folder in Windows Explorer and click



Use Windows XP's 'My Pictures Screen Saver' option to view your photos as a screensaver

on 'View as slide show' under Picture Tasks in the Common Tasks area. Alternatively, right-click any image, select **Open With > Windows Picture and Fax Viewer**. Once the image is opened, press [F11] to start the slide show. You can also view this slide show

as a screensaver. Right-click the desktop, select Properties and choose 'My Picture Slideshow' in the Screen Saver tab. Click on Settings to specify the folder and other settings.

In case you use Windows 98, or intend to create a screensaver file, use utilities such as Irfanview (www.irfan-view.com). In Irfanview, click **File > Slideshow**, specify the folder and other settings, and click on 'Save as .scr'. Save this file in **C:\Windows\System** in Windows 98, or **C:\Windows\System32**, if you use Windows XP.

Transferring pictures

There are two ways to transfer images from a digital camera to a computer. One is tethering, wherein the camera is directly connected to a PC using the cable provided with it. This can be slow and cumbersome and drains the camera's batteries, unless it has an AC adapter. The other way is to use a CardReader. Simply insert the memory card of the camera into the reader, and connect the reader to the PC. Most readers don't require separate drivers and support all major card formats.

Download pictures automatically

You can configure your digi-cam in Windows XP to download pictures automatically when it's plugged in. However, the camera should either have the Windows Image Acquisition driver, or support Picture Transfer Protocol (PTP). Right-click the

camera icon in My Computer, and choose Properties. Go to the Events tab, click 'Save all pictures to this folder' and specify the folder. Now, whenever you connect your camera, the pictures will be automatically downloaded to that folder.

Care and maintenance

Carry your camera and other accessories such as memory cards, batteries, cleaning kit and tripod in a separate bag. Keep your camera covered with a plastic bag to protect it from moisture. Also, place some silica gel bags along with it to absorb moisture.

Never use paper tissue or napkins to clean lenses. They contain scratchy wood products and may damage the coating on the lens. Use a camera-cleaning kit that includes special brushes and a lens-cleaning solution. Keep the bristles of the lens-cleaning brush from coming in contact with your hands as body oil gets transferred onto them. After cleaning with a brush, put a drop of lens-cleaning solution on a lens-cleaning tissue, and clean the lens in circular motions.

Avoid high temperatures as these affect the camera. When in bright sunny light, keep the camera covered in a white towel when not in use. Keep the camera away from strong magnetic fields, as it may damage its memory card. Finally, remove the batteries and store them in a dry cool place if you do not plan to use the camera for a few weeks.